





MUSIC

WHEN SOUNDS ARE MUSIC

UNDAUNTED BY CHALLENGES, INDIAN MUSICIANS ARE BOLSTERING THE FLEDGLING GENRE OF **LEFT-FIELD ELECTRONICA**

Late last month, guitarist/composer/soundsmith Kartik Pillai dropped *Service Animal*, his seventh release under the JAMBLU moniker. Pillai is better known as the guitarist for indie rock band Peter Cat Recording Co., but he has also been putting out jagged, experimental soundscapes like JAMBLU since 2013. Recorded over six months in Kerala, where Pillai was stranded along with his family during the first Covid-19 lockdown, *Service Animal* is a collection of woozy lo-fi ballads. It is also the latest addition to the small but growing oeuvre of left-field Indian electronica.

Casual music listeners tend to think of electronic music as pure dance fuel. But the original aim of electronic music was to break music free from the tyranny of "natural" tone and timbre, to see how far you could push the limits of sound and musicality. And while most commercially successful electronica has become boxed in by the constraints of the club, there have always been artistes, scenes and sometimes entire movements that have kept the flame of experimentation alive.

Over the past decade, events like The Listening Room, Disquiet and Synth Farm created spaces for experimental artistes to perform live. Soon, a horde of bedroom producers and part-time tinkerers emerged: noise exponents Jessop&Co and SISTER, instrument-inventors ISRO, sampledelic producer Babloo Babylon, political dungeon-dub artiste RAVANA, among others.

More established artistes, like techno pioneer Arjun Vagale, have also started dabbling in left-field, non-commercial sounds. Vagale, who makes raw, industrial-edged electronica under the AsymetriK label, says, "Often, one gets pigeonholed for the

> ***With more events creating spaces for live performances, a horde of bedroom producers and part-time tinkerers have emerged***